

A FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

ROOM 207

The Year We Walked Out

BOOK FIVE OF THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

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CHAPTER ONE

The First Day of the Last Year

MARCUS



The first thing I notice on the first day of senior year is that the Mistake Wall is bigger than I remembered.

I have walked past it every day for eight years. I do not notice it most days. It is just a thing on the wall. Yellow Post-its and index cards and a few full sheets of paper, taped up in a long rectangle outside Room 207. Some of the cards are new. Most of them are old. There is one near the bottom that I am pretty sure has been there since I was in third grade — small careful handwriting that says *I told the lunch lady the wrong drink and now I have apple juice I do not like*. Whoever wrote it would be in college now. The card is still up.

I stop. I stand in front of it for maybe twenty seconds. The other seniors flow around me toward the front of the room.

I think — the first card I ever put on this wall, when it was in Room 12, was about Aaliyah. I do not remember what it said exactly. I was seven. Something about a sister and a hot wheel and a small theft, probably. The card from first grade is not on this wall. The wall got moved here in middle school. The original first-grade cards are in a binder somewhere in Ms. Calloway's office. She told me once. I am thinking about that binder when Theo bumps me in the shoulder. "Marcus. Move. You're blocking traffic."

"Sorry. Sorry." He's already walking. I follow him in.

Room 207 has tall windows. There is one long table the seniors sit around — it seats twelve, which is six on each side, which means our cohort of ten plus two for whoever transferred in for senior year. The table is real wood. Old. Scratched. The scratches are good scratches — generations of seniors have sat here. I cannot tell which scratches are from my brother's class and which are from the kids who came through here ten years ago.

I sit on the window side. I sit because I want to see who else comes in.

Amara comes in first. She is wearing a yellow blazer over a white t-shirt. Yellow has been Amara's color since maybe ninth grade. I do not remember when it started. She is carrying a thin folder, which is a new Amara thing — last year she carried three binders. She has simplified. She nods at me, finds her seat across the table, and sits down.

Priya is next, with Hannah. Hannah has been Priya's best friend since third grade and they have been inseparable since freshman year, which means they enter every room together, every time, like they have agreed about it. Priya is shorter than Hannah by about three inches and has not grown since tenth grade. She is wearing glasses. The glasses have been the same shape for two years. Hannah waves at me. Priya gives me a small nod. They sit on the same side, two seats apart so they can talk to other people too.

Darius comes in with a coffee. Darius started drinking coffee in junior year. Pepper is Darius's dog. Pepper is eight now. I asked about her this morning at the bus stop and Darius said *she's slowing down a little, man. She's good. She's just slowing down.* He sits next to me. He smells like coffee. He always smells like coffee now.

Sofia comes in with her hair in a different braid than I have ever seen her wear. Sofia has been doing complicated braids since first grade and I have learned, over twelve years, that the braid means something — it is a barometer. Today's braid is intricate. Today's braid is *first day of senior year and I have feelings.* She sees me looking. She smiles. She sits next to Amara.

Jordan comes in alone. Jordan has been coming into rooms alone since seventh grade. He used to come in with a joke. Now he comes in with a backpack and a face that is paying attention. He is wearing a flannel shirt over a white t-shirt and he looks, weirdly, like a graduate student. Like he aged five years over the summer. He sits at the head of the table — the seat closest to the front of the room, which is the seat that traditionally goes to the kid the room knows is going to be a writer or a teacher or a leader. Jordan, at the head of the table, looks exactly right.

Maya comes in last. Or — Maya comes in second-to-last. Kezia is also still missing. Maya is wearing the same kind of soft gray sweater she has worn for years and she has her sketchbook in one hand. She does not look at anyone. She walks to the seat by the window, two down from me, and sits and opens the sketchbook and starts drawing something. The drawing, I can see from where I am, is just a line. One line. She is making a single line on a blank page and somehow already it looks like the start of a portrait. Maya can do this. She has been able to do this since she was eight.

Kezia comes in at the last second, a little out of breath, in her green nursing-track sweatshirt. Kezia got into the nursing-pathway program at the community college that lets her start credits in senior year and she has been wearing the sweatshirt since June. She slides into the last open seat — across from Maya, next to Jordan. She says *hi everybody* under her breath and pulls out a notebook.

That is nine of us.

The tenth is Mia. Mia is not in this room. Mia is in Pittsburgh. Mia has been in Pittsburgh for nine years.

I notice the tenth seat being empty. I notice it in the way you notice a tooth that just fell out. Not painful. Just — there used to be something here, and now there isn't, and the tongue keeps going back to check. Ms. Calloway walks in.

She is wearing a navy cardigan instead of the green one she used to wear. I noticed she switched to navy sometime around seventh grade. The green one is, I think, retired. The navy one is, I think, her senior-year cardigan. She has been wearing it for the senior class she has had every year since I got to high school.

“Hi, friends,” she says.

The room makes the small noise it always makes when Ms. Calloway walks into a room. It is the noise of nine kids who have known this woman since first grade exhaling at the same time without realizing they are exhaling. I do not know that other classrooms make this noise. I think it is ours.

“Welcome to Room 207. Welcome to senior year. Welcome to the last September we are going to have together.” She lets that sit.

“I am not going to start with anything heavy today. We have nine months. We have time. Today I just want to ask one question.” She picks up a marker. She walks to the whiteboard. She writes, in her familiar handwriting:

WHO ARE YOU, ON THE FIRST DAY OF YOUR LAST YEAR?

She turns around.

“Take a piece of paper. Write me one sentence. Just one. I am not going to read them out loud. I am going to read them at home, tonight, by myself. I am going to read each one of yours and I am going to remember everything I know about you, and I am going to think about your sentence, and I am going to write you one back, which I will give you tomorrow, individually, no big deal.”

“Twelve years. One sentence today. That is what I am asking.” She sits down at her desk.

The room is quiet. I look at the paper. *Who are you, on the first day of your last year?*

I think about it. I think about it for maybe three minutes. I write things in my head and erase them. I almost write *I am Marcus Davenport, age seventeen, son of Reggie and Andrea, brother of Aaliyah, owner of a dog named Cleo*, but that is information, not who I am. I almost write *I am a kid who has been trying to tell the truth since I was eight*, but that is true and it is also a costume, in a way — it is who I have been trying to be, not who I am.

What is who I am. What is the *am*. I think about it.

Across the table, Sofia is writing. She has written maybe two lines and now she has stopped and is just sitting. Amara has written nothing yet — she is still thinking, her pen above the paper. Jordan has written something and crossed it out and is writing again. Priya, Hannah — both writing, both fast. Darius is staring at his coffee. Maya is drawing in her sketchbook, which I think is her sentence. Theo is watching everybody, of course. Kezia, in her nursing sweatshirt, has written one line and is looking at it.

I look back at my own paper. I write:

I am a kid who is learning, slowly, that the version of me my family knows is not the version of me my friends know is not the version of me I am alone — and that the work of being a person, for the rest of my life, is going to be making those three closer to each other.

I read it. I think — okay. That is honest. That is mine.

I fold the paper. I put my name on it. I hand it to Ms. Calloway when she comes around with the small basket.

She does not read it. She does not look at it. She just takes the basket back to her desk and sets it down. The basket is full of nine folded papers now.

“Thank you, friends,” she says. She looks at us — at the table, at the nine of us, at the empty tenth seat that I am pretty sure she is also noticing.

“I have been with you for a long time,” she says. “Some of you since you were six. Some of you since you were seven. All of you since you were children, and now you are not children anymore. I am, I want to say at the beginning of the year, very proud of you. I do not mean proud in the school-recognition way. I mean proud in the I-am-glad-I-have-known-you way. The room is full of people I am genuinely glad to know.” She pauses.

“And I want to say one more thing today. We are going to spend this year working on what it means to walk out into your life. Each of you is going to walk out a slightly different door. Some of you are leaving for college. Some of you are staying. Some of you are taking a year. We are going to honor all of those doors. There is not one door that is the right one.”

“This year, in this room, what we are going to do is — we are going to figure out, together, what each of you wants to take with you, regardless of which door you walk through. We are going to figure out what is portable. What you have built. What the architecture is, inside you, that goes with you wherever you go.”

She smiles. “Welcome to the year.”

She nods at us, picks up her bag, and walks toward the door. She is teaching another class in fifteen minutes. The whole Capstone check-in is twenty-five minutes once a week. The rest of senior English is going to be Mr. Yates, who arrives in ten minutes with the syllabus and a stack of paperbacks.

But for the moment between Ms. Calloway leaving and Mr. Yates arriving, the cohort just sits at the table. Nobody pulls out a phone. Nobody starts a conversation. We just sit.

I look across the table at Amara. She is looking at me. Neither of us says anything. There is a small private thing in the air between us that I have known since first grade — *I see what you see*.

Sofia, next to Amara, breaks first. “Guys. Mia is texting me. She wants to know how the first day went.” Everybody looks up.

“Tell her —” says Darius. “Tell her we are all here,” says Priya. “Tell her her seat is here,” says Jordan. Sofia is already typing.

The tenth seat is empty. But the cohort knows where Mia is. The cohort has known where Mia is for nine years. The pen pal best friendship has not broken. It has bent and stretched and lived. Sofia has the longest text thread on her phone with anyone — it is with Mia, and it is years long, and it is the spine of one of the truest friendships any of us have.

Mr. Yates walks in. Senior year is happening. This is the first day of the last year. I am here.

END OF THE FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

What is portable. What you have built. The architecture that goes with you.

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Book Five of the five-book companion series to The Architecture of Grace